

- In 2020/21, there were close to 1.3 billion UK plays of radio, music and podcasts on BBC Sounds. In the six months up to March 2021, 900,000 more accounts were used by those aged between 16-34 to stream BBC Sounds for the first time (BBC annual report).

Consider how media producers maintain varieties of audiences:

- The current presenters are Emma Barnett and Anita Rani. Emma is a journalist and broadcaster who previously presented the BBC Radio 5 Live late morning show and BBC Newsnight. She has also written the 'Tough Love' 'Agony Aunt' advice column in the *Sunday Times Magazine*, where she explored extremes of peoples' personal lives. Her style is therefore light-hearted yet unafraid to explore emotionally sensitive and controversial issues: 'her iron confidence is reassuring for the listeners ... Barnett gave every impression of effortlessly owning the programme' (www.theguardian.co.uk Jan 2021). This suits the *Woman's Hour* format.
 - Anita is an established and popular presenter on television. She is one of the lead presenters on BBC One's *Countryfile* and has become a familiar face on British television, presenting a range of explorative documentaries for the BBC including *Bollywood: The World's Biggest Film Industry* and *My Family, Partition and Me: India 1947*. The choice of Anita Rani addresses one of the key purposes in the creative remit of the BBC – 'To reflect, represent and serve the diverse communities of all of the United Kingdom's nations and regions' (BBC annual report 2021/22).
 - The topics discussed on *Woman's Hour* are not strictly based around female experiences. Although subjects like IVF, mastectomy and women's safety are female-centric, other discussions about grief, adult literacy and disaster planning offer a **female perspective** on issues that would also interest male listeners.
- the idea that the media is controlled by a small number of companies driven by the logic of profit and power.
- Whilst the BBC is inarguably a large, significant company, the nature of PSB (discussed above) and the content of the broadcast seem to be at odds with the 'logic of profit and power'. Consider the funding of the BBC in comparison with commercial organisations. The significance of the licence fee is that it frees BBC producers from the pressure to generate profit which in turn impacts the content of their broadcasts.
 - The *Woman's Hour* podcast format may also be used to support Curran and Seaton's idea that **socially diverse patterns of ownership** help create conditions for varied and adventurous productions. The fact that this programme continues to be an important part of the channel's schedule illustrates the broadcaster's willingness to produce a programme targeting a specific social group.
 - Consider the proliferation of podcasts across a wide range of topics and genres in recent years and whether the relative **low production costs** of this medium and the inexpensive hosting/**digital distribution** costs offer producers (and often **prosumers**) opportunities to take risks and develop adventurous content that still manages to reach diverse international audiences.

Regulation – Livingston and Lunt (A level)

The BBC is regulated by Ofcom as established in the Communication Act of 2003. The role of Ofcom includes ensuring that services such as radio are of high quality and appeal to a wide audience and to protect audiences from offensive or harmful material. Anyone can complain to Ofcom about a programme.

The BBC operates both a **consumer-based** regulatory model offering choice for audiences and a **citizen-based** one, taking responsibility to self-regulate its content. As a PSB, the BBC has strict **guidelines** about what content can be broadcast or published. BBC1 for instance rarely features sex, nudity or swearing, and all the broadcast channels (TV and radio) follow the '**watershed**'.

Consider theoretical approaches: Power and media industries – Curran and 'Seaton

- It could be argued that *Woman's Hour* challenges